

# Building a Research Agenda for Indigenous Epistemologies and Education

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*One emergent issue in relation to research on Indigenous epistemologies and education concerns the extent to which Indigenous epistemologies lead to new kinds of educational experiences and outcomes and pose new research questions. This commentary responds to the sense of limits and possibilities for Indigenous education that are raised by the research in this theme issue, and suggests that there are indeed new questions to be asked and answered through research. [Indigenous education, Indigenous epistemologies, Indigenous schooling, research on Indigenous peoples]*

As an Indigenous researcher in education, what interests me most about this theme issue is that each paper in some way addresses educational concerns that are shared in Indigenous contexts around the world. Each of the five feature articles raises interesting questions about the possibilities and the limits of Indigenous epistemologies, Indigenous language, Indigenous communities and Indigenous educators, researchers, and resource people to inform educational and schooling systems and practices. The articles address these questions through research that examines alternative systems and conceptions of education that draw entirely on Indigenous epistemologies, public school attempts to “teach culture,” tribally based schooling, and language- and culture-based education. As someone who has been involved in system-wide educational reform, the development of alternative educational options from early childhood to higher education, and the development of Indigenous initiatives in the mainstream system, it excites me to see the range of research being conducted by Indigenous educational researchers. It is important to build the evidence on Indigenous education for reasons that are both educational and political.

In her recent essay in *Educational Researcher*, Norma González (2004) reminds us that the anthropology of education has been concerned with more than what occurs in formal schooling systems, as anthropology privileges and seeks to understand the wider dynamics of cultural systems in which learning, teaching, socialization, and cultural transformation occur. The study of education *in other cultures* and the study of other cultures *in education* seem to be very separate areas of educational research, with the former approach seeking descriptions of worldviews, cultural patterns of socialization, and development in non-Western cultures and societies, and the latter approach more concerned with issues of diversity, pluralism, and multiculturalism in Western societies. In González’ analysis, these two approaches address in some way anthropological concerns about cultural continuity or discontinuity.

The feature articles in this theme issue do not fit easily into the study of education *in other cultures* or the study of other cultures *in education*. Although these articles grapple with a range of educational issues that confront Indigenous communities, documenting different responses and solutions to those issues, they seem to collapse or speak back to the ways in which the cultures of the other and formal or informal systems of education have been studied. The “speaking back” is achieved in these articles with a certain amount of practical ease: The significance of the questions each author addresses draws from the very practical problems that have

been identified by Indigenous communities and researchers rather than from traditional disciplinary concerns; the writers eschew deficit or deprivation views of culture and are fully aware of the colonial histories of schooling for Indigenous communities; the essays give voice to Indigenous knowledge, culture, and community in multiple ways without romanticizing the issues, cultures, or educational responses. The research presented in these articles illustrates different attempts to make education and schooling systems—whether at structural, curricular, or pedagogical levels—work better for students and teachers, and for communities and their cultural worldviews, practices, and contemporary realities.

There are some emergent theoretical issues that arise from a reading of these articles and indeed from other writings in the area of Indigenous knowledge, culture, and education. From a mainstream educational perspective and from any survey of educational research that concerns Indigenous and ethnic minorities, the overwhelming educational concern is underachievement in public schooling systems. The problem of educational underachievement has been studied from different disciplinary and theoretical perspectives and seems now to be more frequently defined as being about the quality of teaching and learning. Questions of Indigenous knowledge, language, and culture have usually been viewed as potential solutions to make classrooms, the curricula, and teachers more responsive and inclusive, with the students more engaged in schooling and therefore more likely to achieve. Although the research generally asks deep questions of structure, of systems and policies, an underlying assumption of much research is that schooling is inherently good for Indigenous children and their communities and the greater challenge is about how to get the best match, how to make it work better—how to fit students, parents, the curriculum, and teacher practices into a system that will work for all.

Indigenous communities often have a quite different set of questions that frames the key educational issue as being primarily about epistemic self-determination that includes language and culture and the challenges of generating schooling approaches from a different epistemological basis. These are at least two quite different ways to think about Indigenous education and the agenda for educational research. In my view, both approaches and indeed other approaches need to be conducted simultaneously because we are not dealing with a unitary, simple, or static set of conditions. There are, however, major gaps in the research that explores the interface of Indigenous epistemology and education and schooling for the 21st century. Reconceptualizing education from an Indigenous perspective is innovative and presents a great opportunity to consider a wide range of educational issues from a different basis. In the same way that challenges about the relationships between schooling and the economy have been dealt with, as well as the de-schooling of society, or the potential of liberatory pedagogies to make a difference for learners in classrooms, Indigenous frameworks for thinking about schooling present new and different ways to think through the purpose, practices, and outcomes of schooling systems.

In the case of New Zealand's alternative Maori language schools, known as Kura Kaupapa Maori, the evidence of their efforts is only just now appearing in major studies such as the National Educational Monitoring Project (NEMP), funded by the Ministry of Education. One major problem with such studies is that minorities become almost invisible in the research and much of the assessment is conducted in the dominant language rather than the language of the children or the school's medium of instruction. The NEMP has attempted to address both issues through inclusion of a specially constituted sample of students from Kura Kaupapa Maori and with researchers and interviews that can be conducted in the Maori language. The evidence to date continues to highlight major achievement disparities between Maori, Pacific Islands students, and the dominant population group; however, it also raises interesting differences—for example, between the attitudes of Maori children in conventional mainstream schools who may also be in bilingual classrooms and Maori children who attend the Kura Kaupapa Maori.

Kura Kaupapa Maori began in the mid-1980s with a very explicit vision of building a schooling option grounded in Maori philosophies and taught through Maori

language immersion. Kura Kaupapa Maori have always resisted labels that described them as simply Maori-language schools or bilingual schools because the philosophy was integral to the conception of education. As one example of a difference that has emerged in the NEMP (NEMP 2004), Maori children in Kura Kaupapa Maori are said to have more “positive attitudes” toward some curriculum subjects than Maori children in the mainstream schools. We can dismiss this finding as too little too soon, or we could ponder over the difference and think about how to explore it further. Certainly in Indigenous education having students engaged in the curriculum and expressing positive attitudes is a small triumph against the grim picture of educational disengagement. The difference from my perspective hints at a possibility, slight as it may be, that Indigenous epistemologies rather than, say, pedagogical styles, can lead to a different schooling experience and produce a different kind of learner. Possibilities such as this open up new vistas in educational research that relate to Indigenous epistemologies and schooling, but we have to recognize them amidst the usual concerns raised by educational research and evaluation.

New epistemologies that inform schooling will produce new questions and raise new challenges for research. The educational initiatives in the research presented in this issue raise many important questions to ponder and think through in relation to a broader agenda of Indigenous educational research. It is extremely important to build rich ethnographic accounts of Indigenous education because these accounts document innovative solutions, telling the stories of Indigenous engagement with education and highlighting issues to be debated or further researched. This theme issue in its entirety provides a valuable resource for educators who work in Indigenous education, and for all concerned with educational equity and justice.

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